A small study.
Useful evidence.

Prepared protocol and recording materials. No resident test, expert review, video or submission is claimed by this packet.

Start with the deadline

The national 2026 rulebook lists October 26 at noon EDT: **11:00 a.m. Central**. Verify the live portal and your district instructions. Prioritize a truthful, complete submission and public 1-3 minute demo. Do not invent results to fill a gap.

Run one session

1. Ask a willing adult for consent. Use an anonymous code and public examples. Keep the facilitator scoring page off the participant screen.

2. Record device, date, app version, prior familiarity, source timestamps and interface order. Use the same device and two-minute task cap.

3. Complete the three prompts on pages 2-3. Record unaided outcomes before help; score explanation quality separately.

4. Export raw observations and the descriptive report after every session. Browser storage is not a backup.

5. Debrief, identify a concrete change, then retest the affected task in a separately documented session.

App and facilitator tool

crestwatch-river-guide.utsavsresearch.chatgpt.site

Append /review for timing and exports; /project for the judge walkthrough; /evidence for dated official-source checks.

The source ZIP corresponds to this Sites edition. Original GitHub and Vercel URLs may show an earlier version. Student names, genuine contributions and required disclosures still need student input.

01 / FACILITATOR ONLY

Read the prompt.
Observe the explanation.

Opening script

"We are testing CrestWatch, not you. Please say what you are looking for and what you think the numbers mean. You may stop whenever you want. We will keep anonymous task notes. This is an information tool, not emergency guidance. Is that okay?"

No names, home addresses or private emergency circumstances. Ask separately before recording. Anonymous written notes are enough. Use willing adults; avoid recruiting during an emergency. Do not publish attributable quotes without permission.

Task 1 / Observation

Read: Find the Mississippi River at Vicksburg. State its latest observed stage, the observation time, and whether that observation is recent.

Correct: Identifies the displayed observed value and unit, timestamp and a freshness judgment consistent with that time. Distinguishes observation time from page-open time.
Partial: Finds the reading but misses time or freshness.
Incorrect: Substitutes a forecast for an observation or confidently treats stale data as current.

Task 2 / Forecast

Read: Find Vicksburg's forecast high and official flood stage. Explain whether they establish that a particular home will stay dry.

Correct: Finds both displayed values, distinguishes forecast from observation, and explains that gauge values do not establish a home's flood safety.
Partial: Finds values but gives an incomplete explanation.
Incorrect: Gives a property all-clear from gauge data or mixes incompatible elevation references.

If a required feed is unavailable, record the obstacle and use not assessed for the missing requirement. Do not invent a value.

Keep the comparison fair.

Task 3 / Official impact

Read: Find the 36.5 ft Vicksburg impact statement. Explain whether the statement proves that a road is closed right now.

Correct: Finds the Long Lake Community / low road to Kings Island note, recognizes a gauge-stage threshold, and does not infer a current road closure solely from it.
Partial: Finds the note but gives an incomplete explanation.
Incorrect: Treats an explored level as today's forecast or the statement as a verified live closure.

Timing and order

Load the task page, read the prompt, then start the timer. Stop on completion, give-up or 120 seconds. Time includes navigation within the task. Record the unaided outcome before help. Keep scoring guidance off the participant screen.

For a comparison, P01/P03/P05 use CrestWatch first; P02/P04/P06 use the official NOAA page first. Use the same three prompts on both, starting at Vicksburg with no threshold answer preselected. Do not reveal answers between interfaces. Repeated tasks can teach the answers even when order is balanced.

Outcome and understanding

Completion	Explanation quality
Unaided: completed without navigation/content help.	Correct: all required elements understood.
Assisted: completed after a hint or explanation.	Partial: incomplete but partly accurate.
Incomplete: gave up, timed out, or source obstacle prevented completion.	Incorrect: substantive misconception. Not assessed: no assessable explanation.

Do not add these overlapping categories together. Navigation success can coexist with incorrect understanding. A feed failure is not a participant misconception.

Debrief: What was confusing? What would you use this for? What would you check before acting? What should change first?

Session notes

Code: _____ Date: _____ Consent: yes / no
Device/browser: _____ App version: _____
Prior familiarity: none / some / frequent
Order: CrestWatch first / official first
Observation time: _____ Forecast issue time: _____

Interface / task	Seconds	Completion	Understanding
CrestWatch / observation	_____	_____	_____
CrestWatch / forecast	_____	_____	_____
CrestWatch / impact	_____	_____	_____
Official / observation	_____	_____	_____
Official / forecast	_____	_____	_____
Official / impact	_____	_____	_____

Use unaided / assisted / incomplete; correct / partial / incorrect / not assessed. Cap at 120 seconds. Export observations after the session.

Actual explanation, help given and interruptions

_____

_____

_____

_____

Most consequential misunderstanding / proposed change

_____

_____

_____

Do not include private identifiers. Retain failures and original notes. Do not substitute practice runs or synthetic test fixtures for people.

A 2:45 demonstration

Use DEMO_SCRIPT.md for the full spoken script. This shot list keeps the required information visible. Rehearse with the actual student contribution insert.

Time	Screen and message
0:00-0:20	Homepage + real names. State app, purpose and audience: helping Mississippi residents interpret official river information.
0:20-0:45	Explore rivers, Vicksburg timeline. Identify observation/time, forecast high and flood stage. Gauge feet are not home water depth.
0:45-1:20	Explore 36.5 ft. Identify orange what-if bar and official impact note; reset to forecast. The note does not prove a current closure.
1:20-1:45	Past floods / 2020 / Highest daily mean. Explain recorded USGS data, missing dates and daily mean versus instantaneous crest.
1:45-2:20	Project engineering. Name TypeScript, React/Vinext, Leaflet, NOAA/USGS and Workers/Sites. Explain actual student work and technical decisions.
2:20-2:45	Evidence page + public link. Distinguish source verification from human testing/property validation. State actual study status.

Recording checks

Readable screen, clear microphone, visible cursor, no private tabs or notifications. Caption the finished audio and verify numbers. Use actual live values or acknowledge unavailable data. If NOAA fails, show its notice and switch to recorded historical data honestly.

Watch the final exported video end to end. Keep it between 1 and 3 minutes. Upload publicly to a supported host, verify signed-out access, then supply the video link in the actual submission. A recording or upload has not been made by preparing this script.

State what the evidence shows.

Report the pilot honestly

Report participant count, actual recruitment, dates/devices/order, per-task correct unaided counts, assistance, incomplete outcomes and unassessed explanations. Preserve the raw export. The Review Lab report excludes ambiguous repeat attempts in full and gives timing medians only for correct unaided attempts.

A paired time difference includes only matched successful participants. It does not prove greater accuracy or general benefit. Include failures alongside it. Small samples, learning, facilitator scoring and changing live feeds limit conclusions.

Use this sentence only after actual sessions

"In a small convenience pilot with ___ consenting participants, ___ of ___ completed ___ unaided with a correct explanation. We observed ___ and changed ___. Limitations included ___."

Complete before submission

[ ] Actual participant names and team eligibility in the portal.

[ ] Personal motivation, genuine contributions and technical understanding.
Record all contributions and applicable disclosures accurately.

[ ] A public 1-3 minute video with names, purpose, audience, tools and functionality.

[ ] Accurate answers checked against live field limits, matching source archive, and public app access.

[ ] Save the submitted answers, video, code state and confirmation. Never replace missing user evidence with software checks.

Primary rules checked October 25, 2026

2026 Congressional App Challenge Rules
congressionalappchallenge.us / wp-content / uploads / 2026 / 05 / 2026-CAC-Rules.pdf

Check the applicable rulebook for contribution and disclosure requirements.
Confirm the live portal and district instructions; this packet does not certify eligibility or submit the entry.